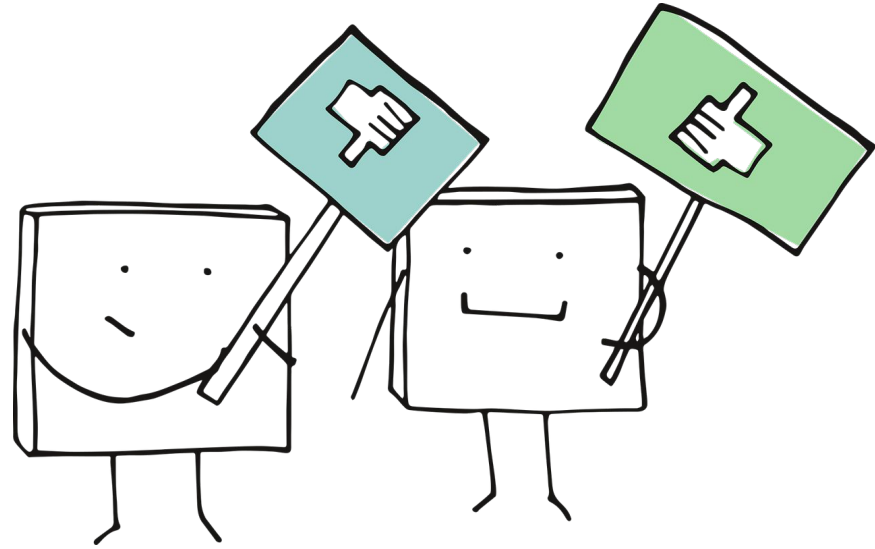


Lesson 6: Credibility of writing

HS192 Introduction to Writing - 2
@ IITGN, 2025-26



Today's learning objective 1

**Find credible research sources
for academic writing**

Using credible sources for argumentative writing

Why is it important?

Are primary sources more credible than secondary sources?

What do you think marks the credibility of a source?

Your source **influences** how you view and conclude

Your argumentative writing is shaped and developed while collecting and interpreting sources. Naturally, your opinion follows your analysis of the source data.

If your newsfeed is full of suspicious information, it is improbable for you to form a fair and logical viewpoint.



Ways to assess sources for academic writing

Authority

- Who is the author?
- Does the author have a degree in the field?
- Is the author affiliated with an unbiased reputable organization?

Note that scholarly articles tend to have multiple authors.

Purpose

- What is the purpose of the source?
- Is it to entertain, to change public opinion, to present research, or to teach?
- Who is the intended audience?

Reliable research articles are usually very specific in nature and relate to a very specific field.

Currency

- How up-to-date is the information?
- When was it written?

Many assignments, especially in the sciences, require research from the past five or ten years.

Ways to assess sources for academic writing

Objectivity

- Is the information you are using biased in any way? If so, does the bias affect the conclusions of the research?
- Does the information come from a source that will profit from a particular point of view? If so, the information may not be reliable.
- Does the source use proper citation?

Depth

- What is the depth of coverage of the information?
A source that is completely reliable may still only give a light overview of the important information. In many cases, you will need to have more than a simple overview of information in order to connect the data to your topic.

C. Buttram, D. MacMillan III, and L. Thompson. "Source Credibility: How To Select The Best Sources." *UNA Center for Writing Excellence*, Nov. 2012. [Online] Available: <https://www.una.edu/writingcenter/docs/Writing-Resources/Source%20Credibility.pdf>

Non traditional sources may yield valuable information for your research, but be skeptical of all sources!

Tips for assessment

Authority

Check the author's credentials/ areas of expertise (e.g., job, title, other publication)

Purpose

The aim of writing is closely related to the central ideas and thesis statement.
See who gets benefit.

Currency

Recent sources are preferred because old findings might have been replaced with new analyses.

Objectivity

Fair writing comes from transparent display of perspective and proper citation.

Depth

Decent source go further ahead from an overview and provide relevant and specific details.

Group activity

- Read “Startup and Go” on p.8 and identify
 - Central points
 - Supporting evidence and reasoning
- Examine the types of evidence
 - (per evidence) Is it primary or secondary?
- Examine the credibility
 - Who and what is the author?
 - What seems to be the purpose?
 - How recent is the information?
 - Does it sound unbiased and objective?
 - Is the information specific, or in depth?



<https://indianexpress.com/article/opinion/columns/how-india-can-become-the-worlds-leading-startup-ecosystem-9781088/>

Debrief

If you are the editor of the science section in Mediva.com, how would you revise the article?

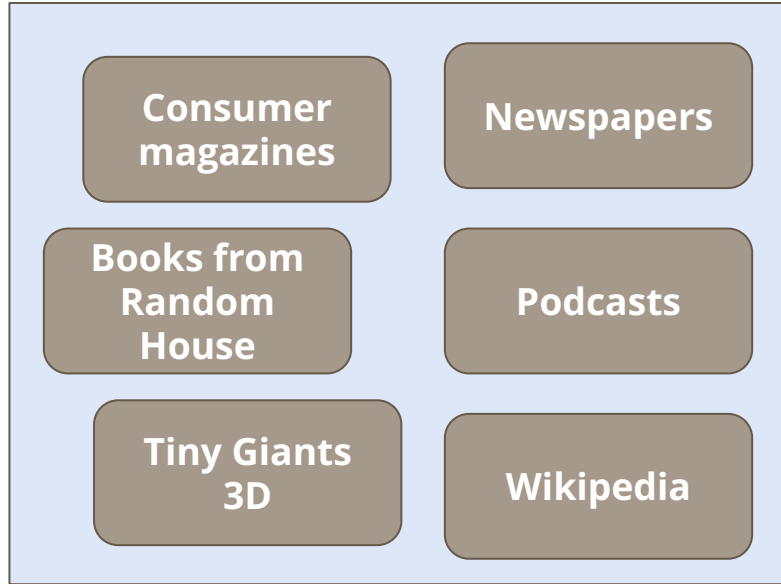
What can you do to improve objectivity?

What others can you do to gain more credibility in general?

Today's learning objective 2

**Distinguish between popular
sources and scholarly sources**

Popular and scholarly sources



Let's make a guess

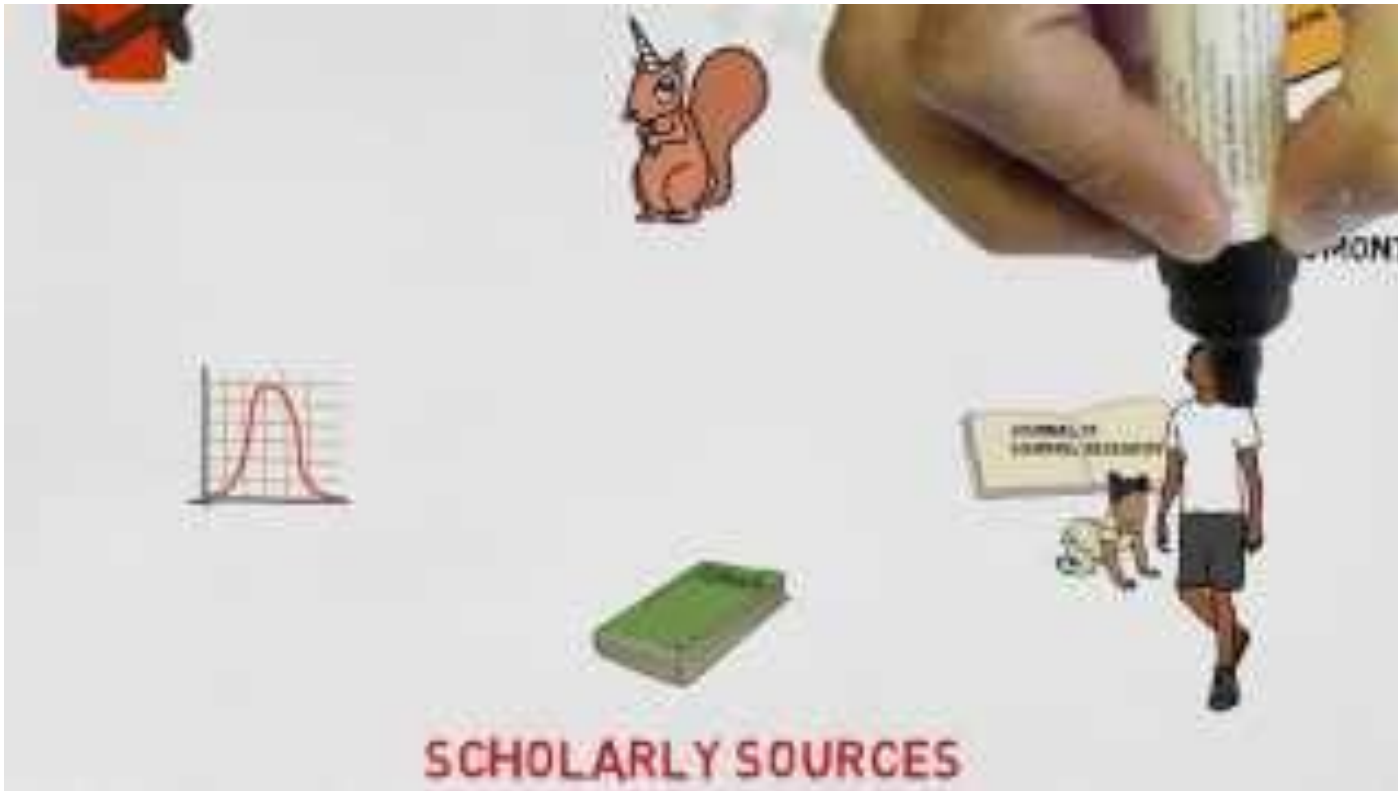
What kinds of information are you likely to find in a popular source?

What kinds of information are you likely to find in a scholarly source?

What kinds of information are you NOT likely to find in a popular source?

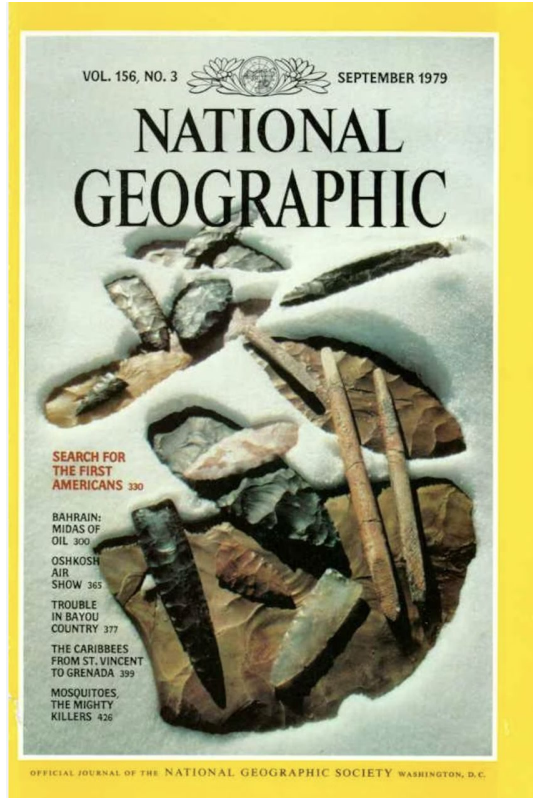
What kinds of information are you NOT likely to find in a scholarly source?

Information cycle



Audience	General audience, all readers	Scholars, researchers, and students
Authors	Reporters/journalists, usually not experts on the subject Authors may not have special qualifications for writing article; credentials are usually not provided For personal blogs and social media accounts, authors may include as much or as little information as they like	Scholars, researchers, and experts in the field of study Author's credentials in the field are established (e.g., institutional affiliation, maybe degrees)
Purpose	Provide broad, general information and entertainment Secondary but not "original" research (the author didn't conduct the actual lab work, math, or theoretical analysis.)	To report results of original research, experimentation or analysis
Writing style	Written in everyday language accessible to any general reader	Field-specific language/jargon; requires reader to be previously informed about field.
Appearance	- Attractive appearance – colorful - Advertisements - Heavily illustrated - Generally short in length	- Dense text-based pages - May contain complicated graphs or charts - Usually will not include color glossy pages or photographs - Very little advertising, if any
Reference	Sources are not cited or cited informally; Often rely on quotes for experts or witnesses for evidence; No reference list provided	Sources cited in footnotes and/or bibliography; Usually extensive list of references

Popular or scholarly?



Peer-reviewed articles

Blind peer-reviewed by
multiple experts in the field

Going through highly
structured and critical review
process by experts relevant to
the topic

Author receives feedback,
make changes, resubmits



How to identify peer-reviewed journals

Peer-reviewed journal displays it on the website

find “About the journal” or “instructions for submission”

***Journal of Human Development and Capabilities:** A Multi-Disciplinary Journal for People-Centered Development* is the peer-reviewed journal of the Human Development and Capabilities Association. It was launched in January 2000 to provide new perspectives on challenges of human development, capability expansion, poverty eradication, human well being, markets, growth, social justice and human rights. The human development approach recognizes that development is about more than just economic growth. It is also about improving the well being of people, and expanding the choices and opportunities they have. Development policies cut across economic, social and political issues.

The Journal publishes original work in economics, philosophy, social sciences and other disciplines that expand concepts, measurement tools and policy alternatives. It provides a forum for an open exchange of ideas among a broad spectrum of policy makers, economists and academics. It addresses issues at global, national and local levels. Human development is becoming a 'school of thought' for alternative economic approaches, and the Journal will act as a conduit for members and critics of this school.

Peer Review

All research articles in this journal have undergone rigorous peer review, based on initial editor screening and evaluation by at least one - but preferably two or three - anonymous referees.

Group activity

One for each group

1. Nature Physics: <https://www.nature.com/articles/s41567-021-01477-9>
2. Physics Today: <https://physicstoday.scitation.org/doi/10.1063/PT.3.4900>
3. Science Reporter: <https://sciencereporter.niscpr.res.in/home/article/895>
4. Education Today: <https://educationtoday.org.in/merits-and-demerits-of-online-learning/>
5. Mathematics Education Research Journal
<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s13394-021-00404-8>
6. Down to Earth:
<https://www.downtoearth.org.in/news/science-technology/rare-dinosaur-eggs-found-in-narmada-valley-show-how-ancient-reptiles-shared-traits-with-today-s-birds-study-87202>
7. Medico Research Chronicles: <http://www.medrech.com/index.php/medrech>
8. PLOS One: <https://journals.plos.org/plosone/article?id=10.1371/journal.pone.0260365>
9. IEEE Spectrum: <https://spectrum.ieee.org/open-source-ai-2666932122>

Debrief

In your opinion, was it easy or difficult to identify if an article is peer-reviewed?

If easy - why so? If difficult - why so?

What patterns did you see in the differences between scholarly and popular sources?